More to know

The Moon is the only natural satellite of the Earth. It is at a mean distance of about 3,84,400 km from the Earth. Its diameter is 3,474 km. It has no atmosphere of its own. It doesn't have its own light, but it reflects the sunlight. The time period of rotation of the Moon about its own axis is equal to the time period of revolution around the Earth. That's why we are always seeing its one side alone.

8.3 NASA (National Aeronautics and Space Administration)

NASA is the most popular space agency whose headquarters is located at Washington, USA. It was established on 1st October 1958. It has 10 field centers, which provide a major role in the execution of NASA's work. NASA is supporting International Space Station which is an international collaborative work on space research. It has landed rovers on Mars, analysed the atmosphere of Jupiter, explored Saturn and Mercury.

The Mercury, Gemini and Apollo programs helped NASA learn more about flying in space. NASA's robotic space probes have visited every planet in the solar system. Satellites launched by NASA have revealed a wealth of data about Earth, resulting in valuable information such as a better understanding of weather patterns. NASA technology has contributed to make many items used in everyday life, from smoke detectors to medical tests.

8.3.1 Apollo Mission

Apollo Missions are the most popular missions of NASA. These missions made American Astronauts to land on the Moon. It consists of totally 17 missions. Among them Apollo -8 and Apollo-11 are more remarkable. Apollo-8 was the first manned mission to go to the Moon. It orbited around the Moon and came back to the Earth. Apollo-11 was the first 'Man Landing Mission' to the moon. It landed on the Moon on 20th July 1969. Neil Armstrong was the first man to walk on the surface of the Moon.



Figure 8.10 Apollo Mission by NASA



The members present in the crew during the Man Landing Mission were Neil Armstrong, Buzz Aldrin and Michael Collins.

8.3.2 NASA's work with ISRO

NASA made an agreement to work with ISRO to launch the NISAR Satellite (NASA-ISRO Synthetic Aperture Radar) and Mars Exploration Missions.

8.3.3 Work of Indians at NASA

People of Indian origin in America are working in NASA and they have made remarkable contribution to NASA.

Kalpana Chawla



Kalpana Chawla was born on 17th March 1962 in Karnal, Punjab. In 1988, she joined the NASA. She was selected to take part in the Colombia Shuttle Mission in 1997 and she became the first Indian women astronaut to go to space. On her second mission on the Colombia Shuttle, she lost her life, when the shuttle broke down.

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